



PHISHING

A W A R E N E S S T R A I N I N G

Recognize • Resist • Report

What We'll Cover Today

01

What is Phishing?

Types, history and scale of the threat

02

Recognizing Phishing Emails

Red flags, anatomy of attacks

03

Fake Websites & URLs

How attackers spoof trusted sites

04

Social Engineering Tactics

Psychological tricks attackers use

05

Real-World Examples

Famous breaches & case studies

06

Best Practices & Tips

How to protect yourself

01

What is Phishing?

Phishing is a cyber-attack where criminals disguise themselves as trusted entities to steal sensitive information like passwords, credit card numbers, or company data.

3.4 BILLION

phishing emails sent every day

Source: Valimail, 2024

Types of Phishing

Email Phishing

Mass emails impersonating brands

Spear Phishing

Targeted attacks on specific individuals

Whaling

Targeting executives & high-value users

Smishing

Phishing via SMS text messages

Vishing

Voice call phishing attacks

02 Recognizing Phishing Emails

⚠ SUSPICIOUS EMAIL EXAMPLE

From: security@paypa1-verify.com

Subject: URGENT: Verify your account NOW!

To: you@email.com

Dear Valued Customer,

We detected UNUSUAL activity on your account. Your account will be SUSPENDED in 24 hours unless you verify immediately.

Click below or lose access FOREVER.

Verify Account Now →

<http://paypa1-verify.com/secure/login?token=abc123>

🚩 Red Flags Identified

①

Misspelled sender domain

'paypa1' not 'paypal'

②

Urgency & fear tactics

'24 hours', 'SUSPENDED'

③

Generic greeting

'Dear Valued Customer'

④

Suspicious URL

Hover before clicking!

⑤

Threatening language

'lose access FOREVER'

03 Fake Websites & Malicious URLs

Real vs. Fake — Can You Spot the Difference?

✓ LEGITIMATE

✓ <https://www.paypal.com/signin>

⚠ Number '1' replaces letter 'l'

✗ PHISHING

✗ <http://www.paypa1-secure.com/signin>

✓ <https://www.amazon.com/checkout>

⚠ Real domain after the dot

✗ <https://amazon.com.order-verify.xyz/checkout>

✓ <https://bankofamerica.com>

⚠ Extra subdomain added

✗ <https://bankofamerica.security-login.com>



TIPS: Always check for HTTPS • Look for the padlock icon • Hover over links before clicking • Never trust pop-up login screens

04 Social Engineering Tactics

Attackers exploit psychology, not just technology

URGENCY & FEAR

Creating panic to bypass rational thinking

"Your account will be deleted in 1 hour!"

AUTHORITY

Impersonating bosses, banks, or government

"This is the IRS. You owe back taxes."

PRETEXTING

Building a fake scenario to seem legitimate

"Hi, I'm from IT. We need your login to fix your account."

RECIPROCITY

Offering something free to get something back

"You've won a prize! Just verify your details."

SOCIAL PROOF

Making targets feel others have already complied

"Everyone on your team has already updated their password."

FAMILIARITY

Using names of colleagues or friends to build trust

"John from accounting told me to contact you."

05 Real-World Examples

2016

Democratic National Committee

A spear phishing email tricked a campaign chairman into revealing his Gmail password. Hackers gained access to thousands of emails.

💡 *Two-factor authentication could have prevented this.*

Spear Phishing

Impact: ~50,000 emails leaked; major political fallout

2020

Twitter / X

Attackers called Twitter employees posing as IT support and convinced them to give access to internal admin tools.

💡 *Verify caller identity through official channels before acting.*

Vishing + Social Engineering

Impact: 130 high-profile accounts hijacked; \$120K in crypto stolen

2022

Uber Technologies

Attacker posed as Uber IT, bombarded employee with MFA prompts until they approved, then accessed internal systems.

💡 *Report suspicious MFA requests; never approve prompts you didn't initiate.*

MFA Fatigue Attack

Impact: Full internal network access, source code, and data exposed

06 Best Practices & How to Stay Safe

1

Enable Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)

Add a second verification layer beyond your password on all accounts.

2

Hover Before You Click

Always hover over links to preview the real URL before clicking.

3

Verify Senders Independently

If in doubt, call or message the sender directly via known contact details.

4

Never Share Passwords or OTPs

No legitimate company will ever ask for your password or OTP code.

5

Keep Software Updated

Patch your OS, browser, and apps to close security vulnerabilities.

6

Report Suspicious Emails

Use 'Report Phishing' in your email client; alert your IT/security team.

7

Use a Password Manager

Strong, unique passwords for every account — no reuse!

8

Trust Your Instincts

If something feels off, it probably is. Slow down and verify.



KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Test Your Phishing Awareness

Q1. An email from 'support@paypa1.com' asks you to verify your account urgently. What do you do?

A) Click the link immediately

B) Check the sender domain carefully — 'paypa1' is not 'paypal' ✓

C) Forward to a colleague

D) Reply asking for more info

Q2. Your CEO emails you asking for an urgent wire transfer. The email looks real. What's the FIRST thing to do?

A) Process it — the CEO wouldn't lie

B) Call the CEO directly on a known number to verify ✓

C) Email back asking for confirmation

D) Check if it's over your approval limit

Green = Correct Answer • Always verify before acting • When in doubt, don't click!

Remember These 5 Golden Rules



STOP

Don't react
immediately to urgent
requests



THINK

Ask yourself: Is this
expected? Does it
make sense?



CHECK

Verify sender, URL,
and content before
acting



VERIFY

Confirm via another
channel if still unsure



REPORT

Alert your IT/security
team about anything
suspicious



You are the FIRST line of defense against phishing attacks.